

Alberta Daycare Financial Barriers

Community Analysis: Why FSCD's "Try Daycare First" Requirement is Mathematically Impossible for AISH Recipients

Submitted by: The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

April 2026 — Community Education Document

Uses public base numbers any AISH recipient can verify

CORE FINDING:

The Government of Alberta sets the cost of daycare. The Government of Alberta sets the income of AISH recipients. The Government of Alberta then requires AISH families to "try daycare first" to access work-related childcare supports — at fees the same government has set above what its own income program provides. The mathematical impossibility is government policy, not circumstance.

1. THE FINANCIAL REALITY FOR AISH FAMILIES

Base AISH Amounts (2026 Public Data)

- Single Person: \$1,901/month
- First Dependent Child: +\$227/month
- Each Additional Child: +\$114/month
- Canada Disability Benefit: \$200/month (all eligible recipients)

Example Family Calculations

Single AISH Recipient (No Children):

Total Income: **\$2,101/month** (\$1,901 AISH + \$200 CDB)

AISH Recipient with 1 Child:

AISH: \$2,128/month (\$1,901 + \$227) · Child Tax Benefit: ~\$696/month · CDB: \$200/month
Total: **~\$3,024/month**

AISH Recipient with 3 Children:

AISH: \$2,356/month (\$1,901 + \$227 + \$114 + \$114) · Child Tax Benefit: ~\$2,089/month · CDB: \$200/month
Total: **~\$4,645/month**

2. ALBERTA DAYCARE COSTS (2026)

Government-Set Universal Flat Fees

As of April 1, 2025, Alberta implemented a universal affordability grant system that eliminated income-based variations. **The government now sets exact daycare costs through policy, not market forces.**

Rate Type	Monthly Cost (per child)
Full-time care (100+ hours/month)	\$326.25
Part-time care (50-99 hours/month)	\$230.00

No income testing. Same fee regardless of family income. Government covers ~80% of total costs — families pay remaining 20%.

THE GOVERNMENT CONTRADICTION:

The government knows exactly what it is requiring families to pay. Daycare costs are government-controlled, not market-determined. There is no “shopping around” for cheaper licensed options. The gap between AISH income and required costs is government-created.

Cost Reality for Families

Children in Care	Full-Time Cost
1 child	\$326.25/month
2 children	\$652.50/month
3 children	\$978.75/month

The “Optional Services” Trap

Daycares can charge additional “optional” fees for: enhanced supervision ratios (required for special needs), specialized programming (required for inclusion), and emergency contact protocols (required for behavioural support). For special needs children, “optional” services become **mandatory** for safe care.

3. TYPICAL ALBERTA LIVING EXPENSES

Housing Costs (Alberta Averages)

- Average Alberta rent: \$1,200–1,800/month (varies by region)
- Utilities: \$200–400/month (heating, electricity, water)
- Tenants insurance: \$30–50/month (often required by lease)

Essential Monthly Expenses

- Food: \$400–800/month (varies by family size and dietary needs)
- Transportation: \$200–500/month (public transit, vehicle costs, or taxi for medical appointments)
- Communications: \$100–150/month (phone, internet — required for government/medical contact)
- Medical/Personal: \$100–300/month (prescriptions, medical supplies, personal care)
- Household: \$100–200/month (cleaning supplies, basic maintenance, clothing)

4. THE MATHEMATICAL REALITY

Single AISH Recipient Example

Monthly Income: \$2,101 (\$1,901 AISH + \$200 CDB)

Expense	Amount
Rent (modest 1-bedroom)	\$1,400
Utilities	\$300
Food	\$400
Transportation	\$250
Communications	\$125
Medical/Personal	\$150
Total	\$2,625/month

MONTHLY DEFICIT:

-\$524/month — *before* any additional costs.

AISH Family with Children Example

Monthly Income: \$4,645 (AISH + CTB + CDB for 3 children)

Expense	Amount
Rent (3-bedroom rental)	\$2,000
Utilities	\$400
Food (family of 4)	\$1,200
Transportation	\$400
Communications	\$150
Medical/Personal	\$300
Household	\$200
Total	\$4,650/month

Current Balance: -\$5/month (basically breaking even)

Adding Daycare Costs: 3 children × \$326.25 = \$978.75/month

NEW MONTHLY DEFICIT:

-\$984/month

5. SPECIAL CIRCUMSTANCES THAT INCREASE COSTS

Physical Disability Maintenance Requirements

Many AISH recipients cannot perform physical maintenance required by leases:

- Snow removal: \$100-200/month (winter months)
- Yard maintenance: \$100-150/month (growing season)
- Emergency repairs: variable costs when unable to DIY

Dietary Requirements for Special Needs Children

- Cannot rely on food banks due to dietary restrictions
- Specialized foods cost 20-50% more than regular groceries
- Multiple children with different needs multiply costs

Transportation Barriers

- Medical appointments for multiple family members
- Specialized services often not available locally
- Emergency transportation when regular arrangements fail

6. THE HOUSING TRAP

Why AISH Recipients Cannot “Just Move”

AISH Rental Discrimination:

- Landlords don't consider AISH “reliable income”
- Credit checks eliminate most AISH applicants
- References required — disability status creates bias
- Moving costs (first/last month, deposit) = \$3,000-6,000 upfront

“Assured” Income Contradiction: the program is called “Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped” — but the rental market doesn't consider AISH income “assured” enough for tenancy. Recipients are trapped in current housing regardless of affordability.

7. ADAP IMPACT PROJECTIONS

Income Reductions Coming January 2027

- AISH recipients moving to ADAP: -\$200/month (from \$1,901 to \$1,701 base)
- Child Tax Benefit federal changes: varies by family
- Total impact: most families lose \$200-500/month

Post-ADAP Financial Reality

Single Recipient: Current deficit -\$524/month → After ADAP reduction: **-\$724/month**

Family with 3 Children: Current balance -\$5/month → Adding daycare costs: -\$984/month → After ADAP reduction: **-\$1,184 to -\$1,484/month** depending on CTB changes

8. WHY “TRY DAYCARE FIRST” IS DESIGNED TO FAIL

The Government Created an Impossible Requirement

THE UNIVERSAL SYSTEM EXPOSES THE TRUTH:

Government sets the exact cost through universal affordability grants (\$326.25 per child). Government sets AISH income levels (base \$1,901 for single person). Government knows precisely what it is requiring vs. what families can afford. The mathematical impossibility is government policy — not circumstance.

This Isn't About “Finding Affordable Daycare”:

- All licensed programs charge the same government-set fee
- No income-based variations under universal system
- No “shopping around” for cheaper licensed options
- Government eliminated affordable options and now requires the unaffordable standard

The Impossible Math

- AISH recipients already operate at monthly deficits
- Daycare parent portions exceed total available income
- Families cannot afford to “try” services that cost more than they have

The Compliance Trap

FSCD requires families to:

1. Spend money they don't have
2. On services designed to exclude their children
3. To prove those services don't work
4. Before accessing alternatives that should be available immediately

This requirement doesn't exist to connect families with appropriate childcare. It exists to create grounds for denying work-related childcare by ensuring families cannot meet impossible prerequisites. It's a bureaucratic barrier disguised as a support option.

9. THE RESEARCH CONFIRMS THE BARRIERS

National Statistics

- 1 in 10 parents of children with disabilities report being denied daycare because of their child's condition
- Daycare centres are the primary source of refusal for special needs children
- Multiple special needs children from one family overwhelm most centres' inclusion capacity

Alberta-Specific Problems

- Age limits exclude children 11+ from most programs
- Inclusion funding is limited to 6 months per child
- "Optional" services become mandatory additional costs for special needs

Financial Reality Research

- Alberta has highest child maltreatment rates in Canada
- AISH recipients face systematic rental discrimination
- Special needs children require 20% higher living costs than typical families

10. WHAT NEEDS TO CHANGE

Eliminate Impossible Prerequisites

For families with multiple children with special needs, financial resources insufficient for daycare parent portions, children who have never been in group care, or documented routine disruption triggers — FSCD should approve work-related childcare immediately without requiring failed placement attempts.

Base Requirements on Reality

Cost-sharing should consider actual disposable income after mandatory expenses, the family's realistic ability to pay, and recognition that AISH income is for survival, not additional program costs.

Address Structural Barriers

Policy must account for: physical limitations preventing certain types of work or maintenance, housing discrimination that traps families in unaffordable situations, special dietary and medical needs that increase basic living costs, and childcare market exclusion of multiple special needs children.

11. FOR AISH RECIPIENTS — KNOW YOUR RIGHTS

Document Everything

- Keep records of all FSCD conversations
- Document financial inability to pay parent portions
- Record any daycare refusals or discrimination
- Save evidence of children's special needs and routine requirements

Understand the Requirements Are Impossible

You are not “failing to cooperate” if you cannot afford daycare parent portions that exceed your available income. The system is requiring mathematical impossibilities and then blaming families for non-compliance.

Advocate for Realistic Alternatives

Request work-related childcare approvals based on your actual financial capacity, your children's documented needs, evidence that group care would be inappropriate or harmful, and your specific family circumstances.

12. THE BOTTOM LINE

FSCD's “try daycare first” requirement is **not** based on:

- Realistic financial analysis of AISH recipient budgets
- Evidence-based practices for children with special needs
- Actual availability of inclusive childcare services
- Recognition of structural barriers facing families with disabilities

It's based on creating compliance barriers that justify denying supports. The math is clear. The research is clear. The barriers are intentional. Families are being blamed for failing to do the impossible.

SOURCES AND REFERENCES

Government Data Sources

1. AISH Payment Dates and Benefit Application, Government of Alberta, 2026
2. "AISH payment details," Alberta.ca, accessed 2026
3. Child Tax Benefit Calculator, Canada Revenue Agency, 2026
4. Canada Disability Benefit information, Government of Canada, 2025-2026
5. Alberta Child Care Affordability Grant Funding Guide, Government of Alberta, April 2025

Research and Statistics

6. "Child care for young children with disabilities," *Health Reports*, Statistics Canada, October 16, 2024
7. "What do we know about physical and non-physical childhood maltreatment in Canada?" Statistics Canada, January 25, 2023
8. "Inclusion of young children with disabilities in regulated childcare," Childcare Canada, Occasional Paper 27
9. "Disability in Canada: A 2006 Profile," Government of Canada, December 16, 2022

Advocacy and Policy Analysis

0. "Alberta Disability Assistance Program (ADAP) would cut AISH by \$200/month," Inclusion Alberta, October 17, 2025
1. Media release: "Bureaucratic & systemic barriers: Inclusion Alberta releases FSCD and PDD survey results," January 20, 2025
2. "New Report Reveals Record Increases in Violence, Poverty, Mental Health Issues," Children First Canada, September 2, 2025

Housing, Economic, and Special Needs Research

3. Alberta rental market reports and housing cost surveys, 2025-2026
4. Cost of living data for Alberta families, various municipal sources
5. Affordable housing waiting list statistics, Alberta Housing Corporation

6. "Negative Response to a Disruption of Routine," Special Learning, March 28, 2024
7. "The Effect of Sleep-Wake Routines on the Negative Emotional States and Aggressive Behaviors in Adults with Autism Spectrum Disorders," National Center for Biotechnology Information
8. "Treatment of severe problem behaviour in children with autism spectrum disorder and intellectual disabilities," PMC, January 2022

All statistics and policy information in this document are derived from publicly available government sources, published research, and official program documentation that any Alberta resident can access and verify independently.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

St. Albert, Alberta · April 2026

albertadisabilitybreakdown@outlook.com

Find the public group on Facebook: facebook.com/share/g/1CrU5PfHha/